

the safety of the civilian population, because the Sri Lankan Government and army aren't even allowing the UN aid organisations or Red Cross to carry out relief measures," she says.

Protests in Tamil Nadu's political spectrum reach ominous proportions whenever the Tigers are in trouble. But this time they have an unusual ally in the AIADMK leader Jayalalithaa, whose Z+ category security over the last two decades is the best testimony to the threat she has faced from the Tigers. Her active espousal of the Tamil cause has put Karunanidhi in a tight spot.

To corner Karunanidhi, who is

Centre and the state were helping separatist forces like the LTTE with arms and aid. But the gruesome murder of former prime minister Rajiv Gandhi by an LTTE suicide bomber shut all doors of sympathy both for the LTTE and the Tamils of Sri Lanka, who were fighting for a separate Tamil state. Of late, the Tigers have been wooing their brethren across the Palk Strait to intervene in the island's strife. Wary of the expe-

dreaded militant organisation, which uses them as human shields. Now India is the only safe haven for the Tigers, who smuggle ammunition as well as medicines through the narrow sea border in southern Tamil Nadu. As the Sri Lankan Army has put a siege on Kilinochi, where LTTE leader Velupillai Prabhakaran hides, the issue has become a hot political potato.

It's not known if the MPs will carry

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PET CAUSE:
MDMK's Vaiko is the LTTE's most ardent votary

affectionately called Tamilina thalavar (head of the Tamil race), the AIADMK chief has taunted him, daring him to withdraw support to the UPA Government if the Centre doesn't intervene in the Sri Lankan ethnic issue. Karunanidhi's reaction has been knee-jerk, though his threat to withdraw all MPs could invite retribution from the Congress high command. Ironically the party state unit chief K.V. Thangabalu is supporting Karunanidhi in this issue.

Ever since the first attack on minority Tamils by Sinhala activists in 1983, the issue of the island nation's ethnic minority has resonated in the state's politics. Till 1990, both the

rience of the Indian Peace Keeping Force and the murder of Rajiv, India would prefer to play safe.

In any internal strife, civilians are the first casualty. Tamils in the north of Sri Lanka have faced tough times in the last 25 years with racial discrimination, poor development and lack of basic facilities like hospitals and schools. Peace has evaded them for more than two decades, partly due to the LTTE's tactics of using peace time to stock up arms. Today, as the Tigers look for a road to peace, the Lankan state says it would prefer a military solution. The darker side of this is that civilians are caught between the allegedly racist Sri Lankan Army and a

out the threat to pull out. Like the ambiguous poems Karunanidhi writes in his party organ, *Murasoli*, the true intention of the latest act of brinkmanship is also ambiguous. After nearly a quarter century of strife, the Sinhalese state has finally smelt Prabhakaran's blood and is, therefore, unlikely to oblige the Indian Government's requests. All that may not finally matter. The 14th Lok Sabha is on its last legs and Jayalalithaa's constant taunts may be enough to make Karunanidhi cash in on his daughter's resignation which may have other MPs following the suit. The LTTE is again displaying its proclivity to drive a fundamental change in Indian politics. ■